



PICTURE COURTESY GARY ZELTZ

MISSING IN ACTION: The crew of Hot as Hell with their B-24 Liberator; the wrecked fuselage of the B-24 in Arunachal Pradesh (below)

GHOSTS OF WAR

India and the US agree to conduct joint military expeditions in the North-east to recover the remains of the crew of crashed World War II US aircraft and thus add a humanitarian touch to their military ties

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It was January 25, 1944. The Allies were preparing for their seaborne invasion of continental Europe and German armies were locked in a titanic struggle with the Soviet Union. Closer home, the Imperial Japanese army had cut off the Burma Road leaving the Allies with no option but to resupply China through an air bridge over the eastern Himalayas into India. So the Consolidated B-24 Liberator bomber from the US Army Air Corps's (USAAC) 14th Air Force which took off from Kunming in southern China that morning, was to pick up vitally needed arms and ammunition for Chiang Kai-Shek's armies from Chabua in Assam nearly 800 km away. The iconic four-engine bomber doubling up as a transport aircraft was dubbed 'Hot as Hell' and the aircraft's eponymous mascot: a crouching nude blonde was painted under the cockpit. Strapped in the cockpit was the pilot 1st Lt. William A.



CLAYTON KUMLES